

The recent UnitedHealth Group ransomware attack, which compromised the sensitive data of 190 million patients, presents a difficult ethical dilemma. The situation is not about making an obvious choice but involves competing views about privacy, security, corporate responsibility, and risk mitigation. The attack disrupted healthcare services nationwide, raising concerns about data protection, corporate responses to cyber threats, and ethical obligations to affected individuals. To analyze this dilemma, we will use the lens of Kantian, Utilitarian, and Virtue Ethics. Each approach offers a distinct perspective on the right course of action. We will also discuss whether these frameworks align, how they compare to my moral decision-making, and how an opposing perspective might justify a different response.

First, let's analyze what happened. One of UnitedHealth's subsidiaries, Change Healthcare, was attacked and had millions of patients' personal and health information compromised. The final total of 190 million makes this the most significant medical data breach in United States history. The attacks were perpetrated by a Russian-speaking cybercrime group, who, after compromising the data, leaked some of it into public spaces. In response, UnitedHealth was forced to pay a 22-million-dollar ransom to the group to keep them from leaking any more information. The attack also caused months-long disruptions across the United States healthcare system, delaying claims processing and impacting patient care. Hospitals and clinics reliant on Change Healthcare's services were forced to use manual processes or alternative solutions during the outage.

Looking at this scenario from a Kantian point of view, which argues that decisions should be guided using a universal moral duty rather than consequences, one can make a few inferences about how UnitedHealth should've handled this situation. The most glaring difference between what Kantian ethics say and what happened was the ransom payment to the cybercriminals. Paying a ransom violates the company's duty not to support wrongdoing, even if it results in short-term relief. According to Kant, ethical leadership prioritizes moral duty over financial or reputational concerns.

Adversely, viewing this dilemma through the eyes of a Utilitarian, one would come to a different conclusion. Utilitarian ethics is a consequentialist way of thinking that argues that actions should be judged by what outcomes produce the most significant amount of good for the greatest number. This reasoning would mean that UnitedHealth paying the ransom to the hackers is justified because it provided a swift end to the healthcare delays and resumed normal operations for patients. However, paying cybercriminals incentivizes more criminal activity in the future. Utilitarian consequentialism argues that paying the ransom is unjustified because the outcome is ultimately more harmful to patients.

Finally, using Virtue Ethics as a base for responding to this crisis yields an even different response. Aristotle's concept of Virtue Ethics focuses on moral character rather than rigid rules or consequences. If a question arises, one must ask: "What would a virtuous person do?" If UnitedHealth were to employ this way of thinking, they would first

admit all legal and ethical faults and offer their patients ample reparations. I also think they would not pay the ransom money, citing it as blackmail to criminals, and thus not virtuous. They would commit to strengthening their security systems for future clients and goals, prioritizing ethical responsibility over short-term goals.

While all three ethical perspectives discussed here agree that patient privacy and security are paramount, they differ in their approach to achieving it. Kantian ethics argue that the ransom payments are categorically wrong, prioritizing the moral duty against blackmail over the consequences of denying the cyber criminals. Utilitarianism, on the other hand, argues that the ransom payments are justified because they reduce the harm to the affected patients, but only if it outweighs the long-term risks (such as incentivized hackers) are outweighed. Finally, Virtue Ethics demands that actions should be morally responsible no matter what, so the ransom payment should not happen. The company should assume full responsibility and pay its patients for their losses.

As I looked at this dilemma, I noticed something about the actions taken by UnitedHealth. Paying the ransom was the company's best short-term solution. While it may incentivize future criminals to repeat the action, I hope the company's security is now looking for such intrusions. What they did was the only way for the hospital and other healthcare systems to resume normal function swiftly and for the company to maintain its credit as a reputable business. In this way, I agree with the Utilitarian perspective that paying the ransom was the best option for the company. While I agree that the ransom breaks an imperative to not give in to wrongdoing, as the Kantians argue, not paying would have leaked much more patient information.

There is an argument to be made that UnitedHealth's obligation as a business is to its shareholders, not its patients. Knowing this, the company must weigh the results of paying an exorbitant amount as a ransom is financially unwise. While this argument has a tiny semblance of merit, it does not absolve UnitedHealth's ethical duty to protect the confidentiality of patient data before an attack occurs. If the company decided to take this route, it would doubtless have lost a lot of business, as patients and customers would see it as nothing but a faceless corporation only out for monetary gain. All companies must face this dilemma between financial safeguarding and customer happiness and what they think of the business.

The UnitedHealth Group data breach highlights serious ethical questions in cybersecurity, corporate responsibility, and crisis management. Looking at this dilemma using Kantian, Utilitarian, and Virtue ethics, each yields different outcomes, as each has a different set of values. Yet, they agree that UnitedHealth was correct in balancing their decisions' short-term and long-term ramifications. Ethical decision-making in cybersecurity requires balancing immediate harm reduction with long-term responsibility, and companies must prioritize patient trust and data security above short-term financial

concerns. As cyber threats grow, this case should serve as a wake-up call for more substantial ethical and security standards to prevent future breaches of this scale.